The weekend it reopened, the Taj held a function for the staff where religious leaders from all the main faiths performed healing rituals and prayers. Then the names of all 1,700 employees were read out loud to celebrate their dedication to the group philosophy.

The next day, another function was held to recognize the extraordinary feat of the Taj employees who were on duty on that fateful Wednesday. Around 1,000 people attended. They applauded for fifteen minutes, tears rolling down their faces, as the 540 employees on duty on the day of the attack and had survived and could make it to the function strode proudly through the lobby on a red carpet.

Ratan was equally determined to preserve the memory of all those who had lost their lives in the attack. In November 2009, exactly a year after the strike, he unveiled a twelve-foot-high memorial in the lobby, on which, under the heading, ‘For now and forever you will inspire us’, were etched the names of those who were killed in the attack.

At the end of the list is the name ‘Lucy’. She was the black four-year-old sniffer Labrador who was brought down in a hail of bullets as she made haste with her handler to investigate the commotion. The dog lover in Ratan felt a compelling need to recognize her role as well.

Exemplary Empathy

Within hours of the attack, Ratan had five outreach centres set up to provide food, water and first aid to all those who were affected. In the following days, he along with some senior managers attended funerals and offered condolences and support to the bereaved families and helped decide on a suitable rehabilitation package for each family. Krishna Kumar and he also visited the injured in the hospital.

Ratan’s focus during the crisis was to accord primary importance to rehabilitating the families of those who had lost their lives. As the Taj employees were readily identifiable, he was personally involved in assessing their needs and requirements. He gave these families special attention as the martyred employees had shown extraordinary commitment and accorded more importance to the safety of the guests than their own lives.

He flew down the families of the deceased to Mumbai at company expense. They were given free boarding and lodging at the Taj President for